

Fate's Edge: Peoples and Cultures

Contents

I	The Aeler	7
1	Core Concept	9
1.1	Affinity	9
1.2	Starting Talent	9
1.3	Key Talents	9
1.4	Strings (Aeler)	10
1.5	Sample Character	10
1.6	Adventure Hooks	10
1.7	Integration with Core Rules	11
II	The Lethai	13
2	Core Concept	15
2.1	Affinity (All Lethai)	15
2.2	Lethai-al — Root, River, and the Roof-Tree	15
2.2.1	I. Ground & Memory	15
2.2.2	II. Forest Commons (Places that Hold)	15
2.2.3	III. Courtesy & Everyday Law	16
2.2.4	IV. Courts & Factions	16
2.2.5	V. Borders & Neighbors	16
2.2.6	VI. Economy of Light (Strings & Ledgers)	16
2.2.7	VII. Threats & Remedies	17
2.2.8	VIII. Tools & Tokens (at the table)	17
2.2.9	IX. Aesthetics & Speech	17
2.2.10	X. Integration Hooks	17
2.2.11	XI. Adventure Seeds	17
2.2.12	XII. Portraying the Lethai-al	18
2.2.13	XIII. Language & Time (Context is King)	18
2.2.14	XIV. Peoples & Lineages	18
2.2.15	XV. The Two Gifts (Body & Mind) & Mixed Blood	19
2.2.16	XVI. Hooks & Complications	19
2.2.17	XVII. Rivals & Distance	20
2.2.18	XVIII. War by Shade — Deterrence & Asymmetry	20
2.2.19	XIX. Marks — Burden, Blessing, and Lost Context	21
2.2.20	Sample Characters	23
2.2.21	Adventure Hooks	23

2.3	Integration with Core Rules	24
III	Threshold Folk Others	25
3	The Threshold Folk: Aelinnel, Aelaerem and Kin	27
3.1	Design Goals	27
3.2	Quickstart (2 minutes)	27
3.3	Play Modes & Scale	27
3.4	Aelaerem — The People of the Hearth	28
3.5	Aelinnel — The People of Sums	30
3.6	Mazereth — Deep Tunnelers (Aelinnel Subrace)	31
3.7	Umbral Kin — Ghost-Walkers of the Aelaerem	34
3.8	Archive Keepers — Knowledge-Bound Aelinnel	36
3.9	Cross-Module Integration (all three)	38
3.10	Threshold Culture Stats Summary	40
3.11	Nook/Clan Sheet (Template)	40
3.12	Threshold Tracks (optional layer)	40
3.13	Gifts & Abilities	41
3.14	Realm Bonds & Complications	41
3.15	Threshold Maps & Venues	41
3.16	Ladders & Procedures	41
3.17	Hidden Knowledge & Surface Connections	42
3.18	Integration with Existing Modules	42
3.19	Adventure Frameworks	43
3.20	Generators & Tables	43
3.21	GM Toolkit	44
3.22	Cultural Deep-Dives	44
3.23	Example of Play	46
4	Beastfolk, Dragonfolk, and Others	49
4.1	Overview	49
4.1.1	Using Nonhuman Origins	49
4.2	Beastfolk	50
4.2.1	Culture and Place	50
4.2.2	Core Feature: Beast Instinct	50
4.2.3	Beastfolk Talents	51
4.3	Dragonfolk	51
4.3.1	Core Feature: Draconic Echo	51
4.3.2	Dragonblooded Resilience	52
4.3.3	Dragonfolk Talents	52
4.4	Others	52
4.4.1	Core Feature: Liminal Nature	53
4.4.2	Bound Obligation	53
4.4.3	Talents for Others	53
4.5	Adventure Hooks	54
4.5.1	The Beastfolk Hunt	54
4.5.2	Dragon's Debt	54

4.5.3	The Vanishing Grove	54
4.5.4	The “Monster” in the City	54

Part I

The Aeler

Chapter 1

Core Concept

The Aeler are masters of infrastructure, economics, and subtle influence. Their power lies in making the world work—and making others dependent on that work.

1.1 Affinity

- **Stone & Breath:** +1 die to Craft/Tinker/Survival for infrastructure; +1 Position underground/urban for system navigation
- **Deep Accounting:** Spend 1 Boon to audit a situation—ask one question about hidden resources/costs/dependencies

1.2 Starting Talent

Vent Prior's Training (3 XP - Minor):

Requires Craft 1+, Wits 2+

+1 die to air quality/ventilation/structural integrity rolls; know the Nine Measures; once/scene read a structure as a ledger (+1 die to understand construction/weaknesses)

1.3 Key Talents

Mint & Measure Path

Calibrated Weight (4 XP - Minor):

+1 die to trade/negotiation/counterfeit detection; once/scene force public bowl (fairness hearing) spending 1 Boon—shifts negotiation DV by -1, gives +1 Position

Keystone Clause (6 XP - Major):

Requires Calibrated Weight

Establish keystone rights over infrastructure/contract/resource (gives String); once/scene pause route/contract/service—convert chase to stand (Position +1 for prepared defenders) or force negotiation

Oven-Warden's Path

Charter Bell (5 XP - Minor):

Requires Presence 2+, Command 1+

In survival crisis, organize communities with Presence+Command (DV 3)—success grants +1 Position to allies for survival actions; once/scene invoke Oven Charter—force public bowl in crisis, ensure fair resource distribution

Vent-Captain's Path

Bell-Chain Signal (4 XP - Minor):

Requires Wits 2+, Notice 1+

+1 die to communication/signals/hidden info detection; establish bell-chain network—once/scene send instant message to any ally in network

1.4 Strings (Aeler)

- **Keystone Right:** Control critical infrastructure (bridge/sluiice/vent shaft)—pause once/scene
- **Grain Surety:** Control food source/storage—force fair distribution or gain negotiation leverage
- **Sluice Key:** Control water flow/sanitation—shift DV by -1 on water/flood operations
- **Mint Die:** Control currency/measurement source—force public bowl or detect counterfeits
- **Oven Charter:** Control public resource (oven/shelter/etc.)—invoke charter protections

1.5 Sample Character

Orra Vent-Prior of Third Stack

Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 2

Skills: Craft 2, Notice 2, Survival 1, Tinker 1

Talents: Vent Prior's Training, Bell-Chain Signal

Affinity: Stone & Breath

Strings: Keystone Right (main elevator shaft), Sluice Key (water reclamation)

Complication: Stone-Press Susceptibility (Spirit test DV 3 or -1 die in deep underground/high stress)

1.6 Adventure Hooks

1. **The Bell That Rang Twice:** Investigate malfunctioning signal system causing dangerous delays in Aeler hold
2. **Bread Before Swords:** Ensure winter ovens stay open/fair against syndicate contesting Oven Charter
3. **Keystone Courtesy:** Bridge "politely rested"—altered keystone tablet; track culprit via chisel marks/contract disputes
4. **Mist Ward Winter:** Repair failing towers with locals distrusting Aeler ledgers—prove math keeps them alive
5. **Charter Kitchen:** Reform Lodge wants winter oven without tithe; broker grain, tame politics, post bell before ledgers close

1.7 Integration with Core Rules

Deep Drakes as Fronts

Use provided fronts: **Stone-Press** [6], **Miasma Spread** [4], **Vent Failure** [4]. When Stone-Press fills, escalate with hallucinated ledgers and mis-signed keystones.

Tally-Law Mechanics

Represent Aeler law through: Strings system for contractual obligations; -1 DV in negotiations with proper documentation; “Audit [4]” timers for contract violations.

Display Rights

Track Aeler status as: Minor Asset (4 XP)—Public Display Charter (+1 Position in civic negotiations); Major Asset (8 XP)—Rings of Account (first voice in open courts, DV -1 on resource management)

Part II

The Lethai

Chapter 2

Core Concept

The Lethai are divided by an ancient curse preventing full access to both physical and mental gifts. This creates distinct cultures excelling in different existence aspects while yearning for wholeness. They master living law, environmental stewardship, and contextual knowledge.

2.1 Affinity (All Lethai)

Choose **One** at character creation:

- **Gift of the Body (Lethai-al/ar):** +1 die to Body-based skills; once/scene spend 1 Boon to enhance physical ability beyond normal limits for one action
- **Gift of the Mind (Lethai-thora):** +1 die to Wits/Spirit-based skills; once/scene spend 1 Boon to recall/deduce information beyond immediate knowledge

The Curse of Division: Cannot take talents enhancing both physical and mental capabilities simultaneously—choose one benefit if talent would grant both.

2.2 Lethai-al — Root, River, and the Roof-Tree

Woodwise lawkeepers, merchants of light/shade, stewards of living borders

2.2.1 I. Ground & Memory

Lethai-al dwell where roof-trees braid sky and rivers think aloud. Memory is arboreal: rings/seasons, storms/healings, disputes in coppice/replanting. An oath is **root-law**: binds living things (people, paths, waters), paid in years. Outsiders see quiet; neighbors see relentless auditors of footprint/flow.

2.2.2 II. Forest Commons (Places that Hold)

- **Valewood:** Tall-canopy forest with rain gardens/stone-steps; trails shift season; waystones carry moss-tallies (green=open, gray=HEAL, black=trespass)
- **Roof-Tree Circles:** Villages around elders—one monumental tree per circle, scaffolded with walkways/rain-catchers; sap consecrated for sealing/dismissing pacts
- **River Courts:** Significant streams keep court: shingle bank, willow-bench, book of pebbles; trade/ferry rights/flood work judged where water overhears
- **Edge-Wards:** Where wood meets field/steppe, boundary groves treated as treaties: thorn/ash/fruit interplanted; sharp feeds soft—hedge law stopping hooves, nourishing neighbors

2.2.3 III. Courtesy & Everyday Law

Shade Etiquette—observing grants hospitality/hearing; ignoring turns forest against plans:

- **Iron Covered:** Wrap bare iron in leather/cloth—covered iron grants Position +1 in parley/request to pass
- **Name Once:** Speak name/intent at edge; do not name forest as property
- **Step on Stone:** Use set stones/boardwalks; every crushed sprout is a Light-Due
- **Water First:** Pour first cup to river/cistern before drinking
- **Leave the Light:** Replace shade taken: plant, HEAL, or pay seed-tithe

Timers for breaches: **Under-Root Grudge** [4] (tariffs/closed ferries), **Stream-Clouding** [4] (mill shutdowns/fish wardens)

2.2.4 IV. Courts & Factions

- **Wardens of the Roof-Tree:** Rangers/surveyors measuring canopy health/poacher pressure/firebreaks; carry leaf-badges/thorn-writs
- **Merchant Foresters (Syndics of Light):** Manage sustainable fellings/resin trade/boat-timber quotas/lantern-wood auctions; argue trade funds stewardship
- **Songkeepers:** Priests of repair rites/remembrance festivals; arbitrate forgiveness by counting regrowth, not coin
- **Ferryman of the Rain:** River pilots/dam-tenders; votes swing courts in flood years

Tension lines: quota vs. canopy; export timbers vs. local craft; river straightening for mills vs. flood meadows for salmon

2.2.5 V. Borders & Neighbors

- **Silence Furlong (Ykrul):** Speechless border strip—no grazing/felling/names; cross in silence, speak once. Honored keeps peace warm; broken brings gray-fledged messengers at dusk. Joint patrols HEAL hedges/lift stones; concessions marked as seasonal strings
- **Ridge Courtesy (Aeler):** Root-law/stone-law trade proofs; Aeler build keystone stairs where Lethai-al choose line; Lethai-al plant edge-wards keeping roads alive. Disputes end with bread in oven courts/sap at roof-trees
- **Moots at the Mouth (Linns):** Ship-timber quotas bind with replanting moots/harbor dues; storm seasons bite—both sides sing river clear

2.2.6 VI. Economy of Light (Strings & Ledgers)

Light/shade are currencies—every fell/ferry/fire has **light-due**: balance to repay in replanting/canal-clearing/trade at kinder rates.

At the Table:

Light-Due System Cash a light-due to gain DV -1 on operations framed as repair/replanting/flood work; abuse it and start Under-Root Grudge [1]

Quotas as Timers: **Boat-Timber Quota** [6], **Lanternwood Allotment** [4]—fill timer to unlock export; overfill triggers Canopy Censure

2.2.7 VII. Threats & Remedies

- **Bark Blight:** Fungal rot spread by careless carts/damp blades—remedy: ash-wash stations, tool quarantine, fire-lines by moon
- **Poacher Pressure:** Syndicates take ripe resin/seedwood without dues—remedy: undercover ferries, tariff traps at market, public shaming rites
- **River Clouding:** Silt from mills/bad embankments chokes fish beds—remedy: settle-ponds, scheduled sluices, mill-weirs redesigned with Aeler math
- **Old Fire:** Lightning scars waking in drought years—remedy: fuel mosaics, controlled burns, ember patrols

Fronts (example): **Bark Blight** [6] → **Canopy Hunger** [4] → **Famine Tariff** [4]

2.2.8 VIII. Tools & Tokens (at the table)

- **Leaf-Badge (Warden):** Once/scene upgrade Position by +1 when enforcing forest law/rescue
- **Seed-Tithe Seal.** Convert sanction into *Repair Project* [4] instead of fine/exile
- **Ferry-Knot.** Skip first *River Hazard* consequence on leg/chase; on use pay light-due
- **Moss-Tally.** Reveal one hidden quota timer in market/lumberyard scene

2.2.9 IX. Aesthetics & Speech

- **Materials:** bark-laminate armor, willow-bone frames, resin-glass panes, river-iron sheathed in leather
- **Colors:** rain green, bark gray, amber, sky-through-leaf
- **Proverbs:** “Leave forest no thinner than your shadow”; “River remembers who spoke over it and what they promised”; “Cut where it wants to fall or do not cut at all”; “If hedge hungry, treaty thin”
- **Names:** given + grove + season/deed: *Talan of Reedfall*, *Who Unknotted the Flood*

2.2.10 X. Integration Hooks

- **Political Intrigue:** Forest syndics lobby city councils for lanternwood allotments; bribes look like “donations” to flood work
- **Caravans:** Resin/seed routes require shade-credit; escorts must mind iron covers and Silence Furlongs
- **Wilderness:** Use Hinterlands procedures with fuel mosaics/blight quarantine as special orders
- **Violets & Stone:** Dock courts host River Days; Lethai-al ferries grant canoe-lane priority to crews who HEAL ladders/steps

2.2.11 XI. Adventure Seeds

1. **The Hedge That Ate a Road:** Edge-ward grew too well swallowed toll lane; broker cut/replanting keeping law/trade
2. **Blight Under Boots:** Bark Blight rides caravan’s wheel hubs; build ash-wash stations without sparking tariff war

3. **Silence Furlong, Twice Broken:** Two violations in one season risk border feud; walk strip, plant apology, write geometry both sides can live in
4. **River Court at Flood:** Mills want straighter banks; fishers want flood meadows; Aeler offer weirs—choose design, stand in water, defend it
5. **Lanternwood Ledger:** Stenographer vanished with quota book before export moot; find them or reconstruct truth from moss tallies/ferry knots

2.2.12 XII. Portraying the Lethai-al

Let **policy** speak before mystique: quotas, ferries, hedges, cost of light. Make courtesy concrete (stones, coverings, cups) and consequences seasonal, not theatrical. Honor forest as **party to treaty**, not scenery. When in doubt, ask: *What did this footstep cost, and who will we pay?*

2.2.13 XIII. Language & Time (Context is King)

Lethai speech is **context-saturated**—syntax legible to grandparents baffles grandchildren unless framed by right place/season/kinship. Meaning travels with **context keys**—gesture, setting, shared story. A sentence lifted from its grove can die on the road.

At the Table:

Context Keys Place-name, season-mark, kinship-hand, roof-tree sign. Absent any two → assume misreadings. When reading/pleading in older registers, increase DV by +1 unless holding Context String (gloss-tree, witness, song). Cashing Context String reduces DV by -1 and creates Shared Frame (Position +1 on first exchange)

2.2.14 XIV. Peoples & Lineages

Lethai-al — *The People of the Body* Woodwise many in most great forests—most humans meet and most willing to integrate in mixed cities. **Embodied and present:** heightened senses, quick strength, ease with weather/work. Most half-elves trace lineage here.

- **Everyday:** Ferry crews, hedge-wardens, resin syndics, ward dancers
- **Gifts (examples):** *Canopy Spring* (Position +1 on leaps/climbs once/scene); *Scent of Rain* (clue on approaching weather/rot); *Root-Balance* (resist shove/knockdown)
- **Strings:** ferry knot; resin share; roof-tree blessing

Lethai-ar — *The Oathbound (Dark Elves)* Wood elves swearing to **Inae** (Weaver, Angel of Spiders) or **Isoka** (Serpent Queen, Angel of Snakes)—rare in upper Amaranthine, growing along shaded trade arteries/cavernous underways. Vows shape craft/law: webs of obligation, clean strikes, poison as *medicine with teeth*.

- **Everyday:** Understory judges, silk engineers, antidote keepers, night pilots
- **Gifts (examples):** *Weaver's Reading* (trace networks: DV -1 on uncovering plots/paths); *Stillness* (be unnoticed in dim light until move to act); *Venin Lore* (convert Harm 1 from toxins to Fatigue once/scene)
- **Strings:** spider-vow token; serpent oath; silk-tithe
- **Courtesy:** Oath-signs worn openly; breaking web-law costs *Mask Rights* for a season

Lethai-thora — *The People of the Mind* Urban circles chiefly in **Thepyrgos**—scholars, civil engineers, translators of other peoples’ law. **Long memories, sharp minds**; ironically many experts on human/Aeler culture. Courts weigh arguments like bridges.

- **Everyday:** Archivists, canal designers, mint auditors, diplomatic tutors
- **Gifts (examples):** *Memory Canticle* (recall text with line-accurate detail); *Number Music* (DV –1 on design/repair/logistics projects framed aloud); *Cold Reading* (Position +1 on first parley when had time to observe)
- **Strings:** gloss-tree charter; canal seal; ledger witness

Sundered Elves (Itinerant Thora) Lethai-thora rejecting bench for road—carry portable gloss-trees, teach context literacy in market towns. Neither fully grove nor fully court, translate between.

- **Gifts (examples):** *Bridge-Tongue* (treat cross-cultural etiquette DV as if in shared frame once/scene); *Pocket Gloss* (create one-use Context String on fly)

2.2.15 XV. The Two Gifts (Body & Mind) & Mixed Blood

Lethai tradition: **no one may bear both gifts** at once. Person chooses/is chosen by *Body* (Lethai-al, Lethai-ar) *or Mind* (Lethai-thora). Training/rites reinforce choice; law/courtesy expect it.

- **Rule of the Two Gifts:** Lethai PC selects Body or Mind at creation; pick Gifts only from that list. Swapping lists requires season-long project with social costs (lose one String tied to former gift)
- **Half-Elf Exception:** Quarter-heritage half-elf (one quarter Lethai-al/-ar; one quarter Lethai-thora; remainder human/other) may take **one** Body Gift and **one** Mind Gift—**Bridge-Born Clause** (rare, controversial)
- **Most Half-Elves:** Descend from Lethai-al lines; default to Body Gifts unless Bridge-Born Clause applies

In play: The Two Gifts are **narrative permissions**: Body Gifts grant Position shifts/physical resistances; Mind Gifts lean toward DV reduction in planning/repair/rhetoric. Do not add new math—use core ladders.

2.2.16 XVI. Hooks & Complications

- **The Gloss That Wouldn’t Read:** Treaty text from three generations back refuses to make sense—find missing context keys or watch border go hot
- **Web-Law, River-Law:** Lethai-ar silk syndics claim bridge-toll by Inae’s charter; Lethai-thora auditors counter with canal clauses—Bowl, then Board, then Shade Etiquette
- **Bridge-Born in Question:** Half-elf prodigy manifests both gifts; circle moves to forbid rite—protect or persuade before masks come down
- **Mask Rights Forfeit:** Serpent oath-bearer allegedly broke web-law in human courts—can seed-tithe seal commute sanction to repair project?
- **The Sundered’s Lesson:** Sundered gloss-carrier teaches market to read Lethai context—someone powerful profits from confusion, wants them gone

2.2.17 XVII. Rivals & Distance

With the Aeler (Stone-Law, Root-Law)

Stone-law tallies weight/span; root-law tallies shade/years; each doubts other's ledgers. Aeler keystone stairs bite deep; Lethai-al prefer lines bending with slope/sap. Trade proofs: bridges not drowning salmon, hedges not choking roads. Keep councils separate when tempers rise—Aeler call elves “Aelaef”.

At the Table:

Aeler-Lethai Relations *Treaties in Practice: Keystone-in-Bark* accords—where road enters grove: Aeler choose tread, Lethai choose line. Breaking either creates fines paid as *repair years*.

Isolation Habits: Pass-keeps ringing bells to one side; roof-tree circles refusing iron even when wrapped. Delegations meet at *split courts*—half oven, half river bank—adjourn before dusk.

Strings: keystone courtesy; shade-credit; river-weir writ; seed-tithe seal.

Timers: **Ridge–Root Stalemate** [4] (project stalls until mixed design signed); **Sluice vs. Salmon** [4] (silt, tariffs, tempers).

Levers at Table: If scene honors both *iron-covered* and *step-on-stone*, begin in *Shared Frame* (Position +1 first exchange). If either arrives with bare iron or cuts outside plan, advance *Ridge–Root Stalemate* by +1.

With the Ykrul (Grass-Law, Shade-Law)

Respect edged into distance—**Silence Furlong** keeps hooves from roots/axes from borders: cross wordless, name yourself once, keep to stones. When honored, councils run warm; broken twice in season brings gray-fledged messengers at dusk; rings draw tight.

At the Table:

Ykrul-Lethai Relations *Customs: Bowl, Board, and Shade*—fairness, then geometry, then courtesy; concession on Ykrul board becomes seasonal *light-due* at forest edge.

Isolation Habits: Markets on margin (hedge fairs) rather than deep exchange; joint patrols HEAL hedges together but camp apart; songs traded by echo, not chorus.

Strings: light-due receipt; ferry knot; windbreak right; border-song.

Timers: **Furlong Breach** [4] (speech/grazing/felling in strip); **Banner at the Hedge** [3] (Meadow banners crowd edge; tempers tighten).

Levers at Table: When both sides keep Furlong and *iron-covered* rule, reduce DV by −1 on any parley for passage/pasture. On breach, increase DV by +1 and tick *Furlong Breach*.

2.2.18 XVIII. War by Shade — Deterrence & Asymmetry

Lethai-al/Lethai-ar avoid open-field banners—make **routes expensive**, fragment columns, end campaigns by ledger long before first arrow. This **war by shade** is why most peoples leave forests alone.

At the Table:

War by Shade Principles **Fight the route, not the regiment:** Break ferries, confuse lanes, erase way-marks, make supply walk twice.

One strike, five repairs: Every cut obligates replanting/flood-work; war ends when repair ledger signed.

Night, rain, understory: Engage when wind/water cover sound; withdraw where canopy eats pursuit.

Courtesy as weapon: Iron uncovered or crushed sprout grounds to raise tariffs, close ferries, call wardens without drawing blade.

At the Table:

Plays of the Shade **Hedge War:** Edge-wards cut/reknet to channel intruders into *dead ground* pockets watched by wardens. (Invader *Move/Scout* DV +1 while *Hedge Mosaic* stands.)

River Denial: Ferries vanish upstream; weirs open at dusk; mills idle to clear silt where pursuers need footing. (Start *Supply Strangle* [4] on any hostile force dependent on crossings.)

Night Lanes: Lethai-ar *web-law* lays silk trip-lines/warning strings; Inae's oath-bearers strike once/vanish; Isoka's keepers use venom as medicine with teeth. (First ambush in dim light begins at *Dominant* for defenders; on hit, intruders mark *Fatigue* instead of direct Harm unless they stand/escalate.)

Canopy Runners: Lethai-al move above sight-lines; arrows fall where footfalls never were. (Once/scene, defenders convert *pursuit* into *parley/retreat* with *Position* +1.)

At the Table:

Deterrence, in Practice **Fearsome Reputation:** Before faction chooses forest campaign, start “**Leave Them Alone**” [2]. On fill, leaders choose tariff/treaty/route-around over invasion.

Intruder Exhaustion [6]: Ticks for lost hours, wet powder, spoiled grain, wrong turns. On fill, morale folds without decisive battle.

Arrow Ethics [3]: Songkeepers oversee. If intruders withdraw/sign repairs, arrows go quiet. If they burn, mask rights come down and ambushes escalate.

At the Table:

Terrain Tags (at the table) **Hedge Mosaic:** Invaders suffer DV +1 on Navigate/Scout; first defender action gains *Position* +1.

Resin Smoke: On ignition, obscure vision/sting eyes; convert first Ranged Harm 1 against defenders to *Fatigue*.

Stone Steps: If invaders step on stone and keep iron covered, begin in *Shared Frame* (DV −1 to request safe passage). Breaches tick *Under-Root Grudge*.

Why Most Leave Them Alone: Campaigns end in tariffs/repair years—not trophies to sell at court. Columns starve by inches while ledgers fatten with fines/ferry dues. Past nights have names (*Two Bridges Gone*, *The River That Walked*); generals remember.

2.2.19 XIX. Marks — Burden, Blessing, and Lost Context

Many Lethai artifacts carry **inherited knowing**. Leafblades etched with moss-tallies, resin-glass panels holding songs, riverstones scored by ferrymen—these do not merely *remember*; they *obligate*. Among Lethai (especially woodwise Lethai-al), **past knowledge is a burden on the present**.

What you inherit, you must carry carefully or set down with witness.

At the Table:

Passing-Knowledge Artifacts **Leafblade (moss-tallied)**: Knife whose edge carries hedge-law. Invoke: gain Context String for border disputes; Cost: tick **Burden Ledger** [1] (owe repair work this season).

Resin-Glass Pane: Sun-cured panels holding chorus. Invoke: reduce DV by -1 on rites requiring old wording; Cost: **Under-Root Grudge** +1 if used to excuse harm without replanting.

Riverstone Book: Pebbles in corded order record ferry rights. Invoke: create temporary *Ferry Knot String*; Cost: pay light-due before drinking.

At the Table:

Marks of the Body (Animist Rites) Lethai **Marks** (ink, scar, resin-inlay) amplify embodied gifts by binding person to pattern. Every Mark has **Context Keys**—place, season, witness. **Out of context, a Mark drifts toward curse.**

Barkskin Mark: Skin takes grain of oak. Gift: once/scene downgrade Physical Harm by one step (Position +1 when braced). Context Keys: shaded work, sap rite, roof-tree witness. Curse (lost context): brittleness—cold converts first Fatigue to Harm.

River-Ears: Cartilage braided with silver reed. Gift: sense current/voices across water (Clue +1 on rivers). Keys: pour water first, ferryman's knot. Curse: flood-whispers—compelled toward lowest ground (SB: *Downhill Pull*).

Spider's Patience (Inae oath): Gift: hold still beyond breath; ambush begins at *Dominant* in dim light. Keys: web-tithe, oath-sign shown. Curse: fixation—DV +1 to abandon a plan once set.

Serpent's Breath (Isoka oath): Gift: once/scene convert Toxin Harm 1 to Fatigue; read heat like color. Keys: antivenin rite, shed-skin offering. Curse: cold-blooded—action slows in chill (Position -1 unless warmed).

Storm-Shadow: Ink of ash and rain. Gift: vanish in downpour; ranged attacks vs. you suffer -1 Effect in rain. Keys: storm cup, gutter song. Curse: thunder-call—loud noises pull attention (start *Noticed* [1] on loud scenes).

Lanternbone: Resin set in healed break. Gift: glow faintly to mark safe steps; once/scene grant ally Position +1 on footing checks. Keys: night watch, seed-tithe. Curse: beacon—predators test the light (GM may spend SB to start **Hungry Eyes** [2]).

At the Table:

Curses as Lost Context A Mark becomes a **Curse** when used without its Keys or against its ethic.

Context Drift [4]: Ticks when Mark invoked off-season/off-place/without witness. On fill, Mark expresses its *Curse* until *Context is Restored*.

Context Restored (project [4]): Recover Keys: return to place, invite songkeeper, repay light-due. Aelinnel *Sumwright gloss-trees* can substitute for witness once.

Burden Ledger [6]: Tracks obligation from inherited knowledge. On fill, pay with repair years, seed-tithes, or forfeit a String tied to the artifact.

At the Table (simple levers):

- **Strings**: *mark-right, context key, songkeeper witness, gloss-tree charter*. Spend to reduce DV

by −1 on rites/negotiations tied to that Mark/artifact.

- **Position/Effect:** Most Marks grant *Position +1* or *Effect +1 once/scene* when used with Keys; without Keys, instead tick *Context Drift*.
- **Mitigation:** Aeler *null-bells* can mute a Mark's *Curse* for a scene at cost of *lamp-time* or *Public Outrage [1]* if used in Lethai court.

2.2.20 Sample Characters

Talan of Reedfall, Who Unknotted the Flood

Body 3, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 2

Skills: Athletics 2, Survival 2, Notice 1, Craft 1

Talents: Heightened Senses, Root-Balance, Canopy Spring, Scent of Rain

Affinity: Gift of the Body

Strings: Ferry Right, Resin Share, Shade-Credit

Complication: Environmental Responsibility

Mira of the High Archive

Body 2, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 2

Skills: Lore 3, Insight 2, Sway 1, Craft 1

Talents: Long Memory, Cold Reading, Memory Canticle, Number Music

Affinity: Gift of the Mind

Strings: Gloss-Tree Charter, Ledger Witness, Canal Seal

Complication: Cultural Tension

Sariel Half-Elf of the Crossroads

Body 3, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 3

Skills: Melee 2, Lore 2, Survival 1, Sway 1

Talents: Heightened Senses, Long Memory, Bridge-Born Clause, Bridge-Tongue

Affinity: Both Gifts (through Bridge-Born Clause)

Strings: Shade-Credit, Ferry Right, Gloss-Tree Charter

Complication: Cultural Tension

2.2.21 Adventure Hooks

1. **The Hedge That Ate a Road:** Edge-ward grew too well swallowed toll lane; broker cut/replanting keeping law/trade
2. **The Gloss That Wouldn't Read:** Treaty text from three generations back refuses to make sense—find missing context keys or watch border go hot
3. **Web-Law, River-Law:** Lethai-ar silk syndics claim bridge-toll by Inae's charter; Lethai-thora auditors counter with canal clauses—Bowl, then Board, then Shade Etiquette
4. **Bridge-Born in Question:** Half-elf prodigy manifests both gifts; circle moves to forbid rite—protect or persuade before masks come down
5. **Blight Under Boots:** Bark Blight rides caravan's wheel hubs; build ash-wash stations without sparking tariff war

2.3 Integration with Core Rules

The Curse Mechanic

The Curse of Division works as persistent condition:

- When Lethai uses talents from both paths in same scene, mark 1 segment on Curse Timer [4]
- When timer fills, suffer -1 die to all rolls until next dawn
- Bridge-Born Clause talent negates this effect

War by Shade

Lethai defensive warfare principles:

- **Hedge War:** Edge-wards channel intruders into dead ground pockets (Invader Move/Scout DV +1)
- **River Denial:** Ferries vanish, weirs open, mills idle (Start Supply Strangle [4] on hostile forces)
- **Night Lanes:** Web-law trip lines, single strikes, venom as medicine (First ambush in dim light begins at Dominant)
- **Canopy Runners:** Movement above sight-lines, arrows from impossible angles (Once/scene, convert pursuit to parley/retreat with Position +1)

Terrain Tags

- **Hedge Mosaic:** Invaders suffer DV +1 on Navigate/Scout; first defender action gains Position +1
- **Resin Smoke:** On ignition, obscure vision/sting eyes; convert first Ranged Harm 1 against defenders to Fatigue
- **Stone Steps:** If invaders step on stone and keep iron covered, begin in Shared Frame (DV -1 to request safe passage)

Part III

Threshold Folk Others

Chapter 3

The Threshold Folk: Aelinnel, Aelaerem and Kin

3.1 Design Goals

- **Liminal Focus:** Cultures living in thresholds, borders, in-between spaces
- **Cultural Integration:** Non-human peoples as complex societies, not monsters
- **Scale & Perspective:** Mechanics reflect size/worldview differences without new math
- **Seamless Integration:** Works with districts, factions, Patron systems
- **Narrative Depth:** Hidden layers and mystery inside existing settings

3.2 Quickstart (2 minutes)

1. Choose Play Mode: Small PCs • Mixed Company • Bigfolk in Small Realms
2. Pick a Threshold Culture: Aelaerem, Mazereth, Umbral Kin, Archive Keepers
3. Mark Tracks: Threshold Sense [6], Visibility [6] (opt. map Visibility Notice on the Nook)
4. Choose 2 Gifts and 1 Realm Bond
5. Start with Hidden Knowledge (1) and Surface Connection (1)
6. Make a Nook/Clan Sheet, map a Threshold (4–6 nodes), and start local timers: Bigfolk Stir [6], Lantern Watch [4], Cat's Prowl [4]
7. Pick an opening Score: Borrowing Heist, Rescue & Return, Underway Escort, Oath Moot, Threshold Intrusion, Knowledge Quest. On any 1, spend from Crumb & Candle SB

3.3 Play Modes & Scale

Scale Tags **Small:** mouse-to-hare sized folk; treat Infiltrate/Hide/Traverse (tight) as Position +1; treat Break/Force as Effect –1 vs big fixtures.

Big: human-scale and up; treat Reach as Effect +1 vs Small in open spaces; Position –1 in cramped venues (Beams/Pipes/Burrows) unless you Shrink the Scene.

Harm Translation: One scale larger → Effect +1; smaller → Effect –1 but may Call a Nook (convert into cover/Position once/scene instead of straight Harm).

Mixed Company When Small and Big PCs act together, Assist may convert scale mismatch into Position +1 or DV -1 if they exploit venue tags (e.g., Small opens a vent; Big lifts a ledger).

Shrink the Scene (optional) When Big PCs act in Small Realms, reframe threats as environmental (broom sweeps, lantern swings, cat shadows). Use Underway ladders with standard math.

3.4 Aelaerem — The People of the Hearth

Homeland: Amedell, south of the Aelinnel halls; neighbors to the Valewood and the Dales

Aelaerem keep a country of gentle slopes and hedged lanes, cider barns and red-doored cottages. They are small in stature and large in memory: a people who bind promises with bread and lantern-light, who measure seasons by harvest masks and market bells. Hospitality is their public law, and the hidden law beneath it is older—hedge-counts, cup-marks, and the quiet attention of the Neighbors.

Hearth-Law & Guest-Right

A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest; many Aelaerem homes keep a guest-loaf token specifically for travelers. Those who enter “under bread and lantern” find their next parley gentled—hospitality is a shield as much as a courtesy.

Lantern-Law & the Wardens

Roads in Amedell are trimmed with little laws: stiles counted “eight-and-one,” village stones turned inward at dusk, door-nails blessed against trespass. Lantern-wardens keep the lanes bright and note which shadows are wrong, while Wold-Wardens speak hedge-law where crowns have no purchase. Offer oil or HEAL a lamp, and a lonely mile may find you under warded light.

The Quiet Powers (Neighbors)

Aelaerem speak of Neighbors who walk under hedges and barrows. Good manners keep them content: leave butter at the cup-marks, keep to the festival calendar, count the stiles aloud. Observance smooths the night; neglect draws the Hollow’s attention, and then small things begin to go wrong—bells toll soft for no reason, red thread appears where you did not tie it, a door leads briefly somewhere it should not.

Seasons of Mask and Harvest

Mummers keep stricter rules than any priest, and the Thresher-King’s guard walks in red hoods when the fields demand order. Festivals turn the world sideways for a night: masks legitimate certain crossings after dark, private moots under the Oak settle quarrels, and an elder’s blessing can make doors open that would not budge for coin.

Yet omens come with revels: scarecrows watch the lane, lanterns burn blue at the ford, chalk mazes fill with mist, and sometimes the Moot Oak bleeds sap the color of wine. Wise folk heed the bells, trade a secret for safe passage, and bury a mask at the crossroads when the dance goes wrong.

Trade, Craft, and Tokens

Cider, perry, beeswax, and wool spin Amedell's economy. Orchard grafts from Mother's Orchard serve as living writs in rural parley; a mill-token buys rumor ground fine as flour; a shepherd's whistle can make dogs and door-bolts heed for a scene. Movers of unblessed pressings risk spoilage—favors salvage what coin cannot.

Aelaerem "hearth magic" is housekeeping writ large: red thread to bind promises, lantern-writ to hold the dark at bay, careful count and courtesy to keep the threshold sweet. It is less spell than system—the precise attention to seasons, doors, and debts.

Borders & Tensions

North, the Valewood's moods drift over the downs: moon-sap weather and dream-pollen make first night omens ring true. East and south, the Rivers and Dales host tight-lipped dalesfolk—stubborn parishers and millers—as often allies as rivals when tolls, water-rights, and mumming calendars misalign. When lantern-law frays or taboos are broken, figures step out of story: a Lantern Bailiff calling midnight moot, a Hollow Bride feeding on invitations, a scarecrow crowned by wrong knots.

Faces of the Hearth

- **Apple-Matron:** Power sits where she pours; feast and precedent are one art.
- **Thresher-King:** A title that moves but never leaves; his guard opens doors none other can.
- **Lantern-Warden:** Trims lamps, reads shadows; escorts earned with oil and respect.
- **Mummers' Captain:** Lawful masks and after-dark crossings on feast-days—anger them and gates close at dusk.
- **Miller & Watch-Geese:** Local alarm and local court in one flock and wheel.
- **The Pale Shepherd:** Once, pass uncounted; always, pay the lane its due.

Play Hooks in Amedell

- **The Guest-Loaf Forgers:** Counterfeit tokens sour trust from Amedell to the Way of Silk; track the mummers' license that legitimized the forgeries, or every night road turns hostile.
- **The Moot Oak Bleeds:** A festival omen turns ugly; mediate before the Hollow answers the knives.
- **Lanterns at the Ford:** Blue flames demand a toll "more than coin"; learn what the Neighbors want this season.
- **Apple-Matron's Summons:** Refuse her table and prices double; accept, and you inherit a feud with the dalesmen downstream.

Using the Aelaerem at the Table

Treat bread, lamps, and counting as levers: produce guest-loaf and a lit lantern to soften a risky social exchange; observe courtesies to cancel the first strange complication in a scene; pause at a stile and listen to ask what the Hollow wants right now. Even in danger, a shepherd's whistle or mill-token can turn fiction your way—Amedell rewards those who mind the little laws.

In Amedell, the hearth is a treaty, the lane a ledger, and the night a neighbor. Keep the count, pour the cup, and the country will keep you.

3.5 Aelinnel — The People of Sums

Homeland: Gnomeholds in the hawthorn hills south of the Valewood; stone, bough, and bright things.

The Aelinnel keep to counted roads and measured courtesies. Their halls run like veins through granite and hawthorn; their bridges hum when tuned; their bargains arrive on two ledgers—what was said, and what was meant. To walk their country is to feel math underfoot: steps that are safer when even, doors that open to the right sequence, moonlight that prefers tidy logic.

The Hawthorn Halls

South of the Valewood, the hills break into stone spurs and thorn-sheltered gullies. Paths are counted by antler-posts; tide-cut stairs descend to black sea-rifts; causeys of pale flags show themselves at dawn, at dusk—and whenever someone is counting aloud. Basalt organ cliffs breathe in primes; a moonwell stains coins green faster than names; dolmen stairs ring true if you tap the right interval.

Winged gnomes—fae-kin cousins with leaf-thin pinions—roost in hawthorn crowns and act as go-betweens to the courts. Gnomes as a whole resemble smaller, bright-eyed elves; the winged are simply closer to the other side of the hedge.

Law of Sums (Courtesy, Copper, Count)

Aelinnel civility is exact: count or be counted. Speak your steps, breaths, or stitches and the land steadies—Position shifts safer for acts that exploit pattern or timing. Favor copper over iron before the courts; copper is polite, iron is an insult unless named or gilded. Recite a simple sequence when tension frays to cancel the first misstep in navigation or negotiation.

Courts of hawthorn require three clean courtesies: do not bring naked iron; speak in two ledgers; return what points the way (chalk, cord, antler). Keep them, and even thorns hold back; slight them, and arches close, time drifts, and conversations arrive folded and misaddressed.

Table Levers

- **Counting Etiquette:** Once/scene, careful counting shifts Position +1 for patterned action.
- **Copper over Iron:** Displaying copper/brass tools avoids the first fae-offense penalty in a scene.
- **Two-Ledger Talk:** State what was said and what was meant to cancel the first social SB this scene.

People of Stone & Bough

You'll meet charcoal-burners who read omen by smoke hums; stone-singers whose low chords relax walls; forester-wardens who hammer copper nails where iron offends; goat-herds who measure danger in hoof-widths. Markets under living roofs sell truths wrapped for travel; weights and measures matter—producing a certified rod cancels the first jurisdiction or commerce snag.

Reputation echoes. Earn Hazel Favors by returning way-cords, restoring antler posts, paying tide-dues; spend to downgrade a glamour or geas once per leg. Masks and marks—Thorn-Courteous, Market-Square, Forester-Trusted—change which doors open and which clerks squint.

Courts, Hunts, and Gates

Aelinnel bosses are etiquette engines and logic traps more than villains. The Lady of Thorns punishes breaches precisely and rewards perfect sequences; the Green Knight duels by paths and proofs; the Moonlit Ride offers one night’s clemency if you name the right horn-count; the Green Gate demands exact change in truths.

When an Ace turns up in their stories, echo the motifs: antlers in shadow, petals that cut, a breathing tide, and shortcuts that insist on proper counting.

Tides, Ledgers, and Names

Rivers and sea-caves carry their own arithmetic. Tide-reeves file plans before neap to earn a Tide Window; skip the ledger and the first Dolmis crossing suffers Wrong Tide. Barge seals that aren’t maintained invite Wrong Hour. In green markets, you’ll sometimes submit a said/meant receipt—try single-ledger haggling and the stalls mark you Exact Change Only, with memory or name demanded to square the sum.

Aelinnel Mood: Dark-Wonder

Think “math-bright Alice” under a hawthorn sky: paths shorten for those who keep count and lengthen for the proud; petals fall like knives and settle into proofs; moonlight reveals hidden routes; antler-posts rearrange themselves when the land takes offense. Time miscounts and the sun arrives at the wrong hour with excellent logic.

3.6 Mazereth — Deep Tunnelers (Aelinnel Subrace)

Stone-song, pressure shafts, and the etiquette of bearings & bridges

South of the Valewood the hills become ribbed stone and root-warrens, and the Aelinnel subculture called the **Mazereth** trace their lives along pressure lines and strata seams. Their halls feel like organs that breathe—pillars tuned to low chords, vents that whisper the time, chalk glyphs that count the load of a wall. But Mazereth are not only cave-keen: they tend weighhouses, keep ledgers for bridge trusts, and carry bearing-cords across market towns. They greet the hill with a palm on stone and a measure of weight; they greet the street with a counted price and a clean tally.

Stone-Law (Courtesy of Bearings)

- **Count the Load.** Tap a support *or* beam three times and listen; once/scene, a measured tap sequence grants **Position +1** to *Traverse/Endure* in caves, bridges, or crowded structures.
- **Copper Courtesy.** Copper is polite to stone and honest to labor. Presenting copper tools or a mason’s tally *negates the first environment SB* tied to structure stress *or* grants **DV −1** to parley with miners/masons/porters.
- **Return the Chalk.** Anything that points the way (chalk, cord, placards) must be restored; doing so **cancels the first environment SB** this scene (dust, sway, signage loss).
- **Two Bearings, One Path.** When asking directions, give both slope and seam (“down-two, east-by-vein”) *or* price and span (“two-pence, one-arch”); this **cancels the first social SB** with wardens/foremen/brokers.

Heritage & Build (as Aelinnel)

Mazereth use **Aelinnel** baselines; apply the following package.

Traits

- **Medium-Small; Strata Sense:** *once/scene*, gain **+1 die** on a roll that reads load, route, or crowd-flow (Survey, Lore: Structures, Tactics: Maneuver) in stonework, bridges, or packed markets.
- **Pressure Adaptation:** *once/scene*, ignore the first **Desperate** caused by crush/squeeze *or* stampede/crowd surge.

Gifts (choose 2)

- **Deep Earthen Sense:** Vibration mapping; **Navigate DV -1** below ground or in heavy stoneworks.
- **Tunnel Craft:** Declare a safe crawl, drain, or bypass **once/score**; GM sets a short timer to open it.
- **Pressure Resistance:** Reduce crush/fall **Harm by one step** (to Fatigue if possible) *once/scene*.
- **Pattern Reading:** Beam/arch logic; **Disable/Repair DV -1** for structural tasks and braces.
- **Bearing Factor:** In worksites/weighhouses, your clean ledger grants **DV -1** to negotiate labor, tolls, or right-of-way.
- **Cord Etiquette:** Under a marked cord/line, you and guests gain **Position +1** on the opening exchange of parley or passage.

Complications (choose 1)

- **Surface Sickness:** Open sky disorients—start scene at **Position -1** outdoors until you ground with a counted-breath ritual.
-
- **Light Sensitivity:** First bright flare each scene triggers **Lantern Sway** (ranged penalties; GM tick or tag).
- **Counting Compulsion:** Under stress, you stall to count supports; GM may **bank +1 SB** if you refuse, or you **mark 1 Fatigue** if you indulge.

Cultural Paths (pick one flavor; grants a situational edge)

- **Tunnelwright:** When you *prepare terrain*, your first brace/prop this scene adds a **Stability** tag (Position +1 vs collapse).
- **Wayfactor:** At a bridge/ford/weighhouse, **DV -1** on the first toll/permit check each scene.
-
- **Cord-Keeper:** While your bearing-cord is up, allies treating it as a guide gain **+1 die** to Traverse *once/scene*.

Places & Omens

- **Organ Cliffs:** basalt pipes that “breathe” in primes; wrong echoes mean a collapse front.
- **Green Vein:** a copper seam used for oaths; promises sworn here bind extra tight.
- **Sump of Coins:** a moonwell that stains copper; a safe ford when counted in fives.
- **Foothill Weighhouse:** ledgers, cords, and posts; disputes settled by span and load before coin.
- **Omens:** dust that falls upward; pebbles ticking in sequence; roots that beat like a slow heart.

Faces of Stone

- **Bearing-Reeve Bronze:** audits props and pistons; will trade three good spans for one good ledger.
- **Chalk-Warden Ness:** scolds for stolen marks; swaps you a shortcut if you return a cord intact.
- **Goat-Singer Ivryn:** her herd keeps time on cliff paths; she knows which ledges forgive missteps.
- **Span-Broker Telma:** keeps the toll honest; buys you Position +1 in parley if your bearings are clean.

Strings & Tokens

seam-chalk, bearing cord, copper nail ring, pressure bead (changes hue under load), weighhouse scrip, mason’s tally.

Timers & Hazards

- **Stone Attention [6]** (the hill “notices” you), **Squeeze Front [4]**, **Bad Air [4]**, **Vein Quarrel [4]**, **Rain-Swell [4]** (flooded cuts), **Market Panic [4]** (crowd crush).
- **SB Menu (Underground/Works & Markets):** Dust Plume (visibility), Lantern Sway (glare), Slick Calcite (lose Position), Root Snare (pursuit begins), Sour Air (Fatigue), Toll Dispute (parley Position −1), Span Creak (start Stability timer).

Play Hooks

1. **Kiln in Thirds:** A charcoal draft hums off-pattern; fix the count before the Green Vein judges the debt.
2. **The Swallowing Span:** A climbing route “shortens” for liars—prove truth with two bearings.
3. **The Stolen Chalk:** A market steals way-marks for profit; restore cords or Stone Attention wakes a sleeping fault.
4. **Bridge Trust Audit:** The toll rose without span repair; expose the false ledger or brace the arch mid-parley.

Using Mazereth at the Table

Lean on **Strata Sense** for DV breaks in stonework *and* tight urban spaces. Spend **bearing cords** as Strings for **Traverse +1 Position**, and treat **copper courtesy** as a one-shot ward against structure/environment SB *or* a DV nudge with labor strata. Above ground, **Surface Sickness** is a soft tax the first minute of a scene—ground with counted breath to clear it. In banner play, a Mazereth Wayfactor smooths crossings; in dungeon play, a Tunnelwright quietly prevents the TPK.

3.7 Umbral Kin — Ghost-Walkers of the Aelaerem

Twilight courtesies, reflection roads, and the price of borrowed shade

The Umbral Kin are Aelaerem cousins who learned to live *with* their shadows rather than flee them. They rent shade like others rent rooms, keep glazier ledgers alongside family bibles, and treat ward-lamps as municipal judges: name them, appease them, or slip between their gazes. In markets they stand where awnings overlap; on roads they walk the cool edge; at home they hang lamp hoods before a greeting.

Shadow-Law (Etiquette of Edges)

- **Speak on the Edge.** Begin parley half-in, half-out of shadow (doorway, awning, lintel). *Once/scene*, gain **Position +1** on **Sway/Diplomacy** for the opening exchange.
- **No Naked Lights.** Unshaded flame is insult and provocation. A covered lantern (hood, shade, or hand-screen) *negates the first ward-lamp penalty or flare* this scene.
- **Mirror Oath.** Swear with faces side-by-side in a window or polished plate. *Once/session*, a mirror-oath counts as a **Witness** for disputes, contracts, or safe-conduct.
- **Name the Shade.** At dusk, name your shadow and touch heel to heel. *This leg*, cancel the first **Memory Echo** complication that would expose you.

Heritage & Build (as Aelaerem)

Umbral Kin use **Aelaerem** baselines; apply this package.

Traits

- **Small–Medium; Shadow Blend:** In dim/dappled light you count as having *soft cover*; *once/scene* gain **+1 die** to **Stealth/Subterfuge** when entering or leaving a shadowed zone.
- **Reflection Reading:** *Once/scene*, study glass or still water to ask 1: "Who's watching?" "What was just done here?" "Where is the lamp's blind side?"

Gifts (choose 2)

- **Shadow Step:** *Near-range* hop between contiguous shadows you can see. Costs **1 Fatigue** if crossing open light; otherwise free.
- **Memory Echo:** Read emotional residue from a cool surface; on success gain **Clue +1** (lead timer +1) but GM may tick **Ward-Lamp Attention** if you linger.
- **Light Bending:** *Once/scene*, stage the light (hood, sheet, mirrored dish) to gain **Position +1** for a vanish/misdirect.
- **Partial Phase:** Squeeze through a bar, grille, or door-gap by marking **1 Fatigue**; if you would take **Harm 1**, convert it to **1 Fatigue** instead.
- **Lantern Cant:** You know the lamplighters' marks; **DV –1** to navigate after curfew or to spoof a lamp's patrol route.

Complications (choose 1)

- **Bleach-Sick:** Harsh illumination (no shade) starts you at **Position -1** until you create or reach cover.
- **Ward-Lamp Attention:** Named streetlamps *remember* you; the GM may tick **Ward-Lamp Attention** [6] when you commit a notable act in view.
- **Two Shadows:** At noon or under crossed lights you cast a double; the first **Subterfuge** each scene is **DV +1** unless you dim one source.

Guild Paths (pick one flavor; adds a situational edge)

- **Night Courier:** When you *carry under writ*, your first **Traverse/Stealth** this leg gains **DV -1**.
- **Glazier of Quiet:** While you work a pane or mirror "set for silence," allies in Near count as **Hidden** from casual watchers until they act.
- **Parasol Marshal:** In zones you've flagged with shade markers, your side starts **Position +1** against ward patrols and informers.

Places & Omens

- **Reflection Lanes:** Arcades where one may "walk the pane" if step and breath match the double.
- **Blue Hours:** Docks where time comes twice; safer to leave before names are called.
- **Umbrelle Market:** Awnings upon awnings; secrets priced in shade.
- **Omens:** Lamps that flare without wind; a second shadow arriving late; reflections that refuse to smile.

Faces of Twilight

- **Parasol-Matron Sevi:** Rents legal shade; will cover a fugitive for one favor paid at dawn.
- **Lamplighter Orr:** Turns ward-lamps to "rest" on a name; looks away if you speak his grandmother's lullaby.
- **Glazier Moth:** Sets "forgetful panes" that blunt Memory Echo for a week (and bill you twice).

Strings & Tokens

parasol writ; shade-marker ribbon; mirror-shard oath; lamp hood; lamplighter's chalk.

Timers & Hazards

- **Ward-Lamp Attention** [6] (streetlights learn you), **Glare Front** [4], **Reflection Stalker** [4], **Blue Hour Drift** [4], **Curfew Sweep** [4].
- **SB Menu (Shadow):** Lamp Flare (scene brightens); Second Shadow (a pursuer appears); Glass Whisper (old rumor resurfaces); Dawn Soon (time compresses); Hood Snag (lose cover).

Play Hooks

1. **The Lamp That Watches:** A new ward-lamp memorizes faces; steal its name-plate before it "testifies."
2. **Blue Hour Heist:** A vault exists twice at twilight; rob the reflection while your doubles distract the guards.
3. **Parasol Tax:** City watch bans uncovered candles; smuggling lamp hoods becomes a civic rebellion.
4. **The Second Shadow:** Someone wears your late shadow in the markets; retrieve it before your debts follow.

Using Umbral Kin at the Table

Treat covered light as a one-shot **DV -1** vs. ward systems; **mirror shards** can invoke **Witness** per *Mirror Oath*. Trade **Memory Echo** for fast clues at the risk of **Ward-Lamp Attention** ticking. In bright scenes, expect an initial **Position -1** unless you fix the light; **Light Bending** or a **lamp hood** clears it. **Shadow Step** is Near-range and demands real, contiguous shade—alleys, awnings, cart undersides—keeping the talent street-grounded rather than supernatural flight.

3.8 Archive Keepers — Knowledge-Bound Aelinnel

Index courts, pattern webs, and the peril of perfect memory

The Archive Keepers are Aelinnel cousins who hoard what others forget. They curate hidden stacks, stitch ledgers to ledgers, and build "pattern webs" that let a fact walk from one book to another. Their manners are footnotes; their quarrels are citations; their pride is a shelf that never lies.

Index Law (Etiquette of Records)

- **Cite or be Cited.** Offer a source when making a claim; *once/scene*, a clean citation grants **DV -1** to **Plan/Research/Petition**.
- **Return the Page.** Replace a card where it belongs to cancel the first *Index Entropy* complication this scene.
- **Two Copies, Two Locks.** A binding writ needs twin copies kept apart; declaring both voids the first *forgery SB* this scene.
- **Right of Errata.** Admit a small error to avoid a larger duel; convert a looming *Sting/Inspection* into a lesser **Public Correction** [4].

Traits, Gifts, Complications

Traits

- **Small; Stacks-Hardened.** Treat ladders, rolling stools, and shelf-rungs as *normal ground*; ignore the first *Climb* penalty in libraries and scriptoriums.
- **Index Sense.** *Once/scene*, ask a pattern question: "What's missing?" "What contradicts itself?" or "Where would this belong?"
- **Shelf-Strider.** You can "squeeze" through densely packed aisles; tight passages count as one size wider for you.

Gifts (pick 2)

- **Knowledge Tap.** You keep a hidden index of topics; gain **DV -1** on **Lore/Investigation** when you can cite a plausible prior source.
- **Memory Palace.** Store a scene perfectly; later "quote" it to gain **Clue +1** or **Position +1** to disprove a lie (once/scene).
- **Information Bridge.** Join two records with cross-refs; allies pursuing that lead gain **Clue +1** (lead timer +1) this scene.
- **Threshold Architecture.** Lay a subtle through-route with ribbons, tabs, and marks; *once/session* your party gets **Traverse DV -1** through stacks/archives.

Complications (choose 1)

- **Overload.** Too many inputs at once mark **1 Fatigue** and impose **-1 die** on your next **Insight/Notice**.
- **Brittle Focus.** Blunt impacts shake you; the first **Harm 1 (blunt)** in a scene converts to **1 Fatigue**, then resolve Harm normally after.

Places & Omens

- **Stack Nine-Between:** a shelf that appears where two libraries agree; reachable by whispering the same title.
- **Red Thread Court:** disputes settled by re-stitching a ledger; scissors are weapons here.
- **Binder's Bridge:** a paper-arc you can cross if your name is spelled correctly.
- **Omens:** margins writing back; page numbers that skip a friend's birthday; a shelf that turns its own ladder.

Faces of the Index

- **Card-Clerk Lumo:** knows where the lost catalog sleeps; demands an errata signed in copper.
- **Binder-Monk Pera:** can unmake a contract by re-sewing it; always asks for a memetic tithe.
- **Ink-Archivist Thriss:** drinks spoiled ink to taste lies; offers detox at a price.

Strings & Tokens

errata slip; card-catalog tag; binder's thread; reference stamp (acts as *Witness* for documents once).

Timers & Hazards

- **Index Entropy [6]** (systems decay), **Leak of Names [4]**, **Plagiarism Duel [4]**, **Redaction Front [6]**.
- **SB Menu (Stacks):** Shelf Creep (path shifts), Loose Leaf (evidence scatters), Citation War (resource tax), Spilled Ink (Visibility rises).

Play Hooks

1. **The Missing Reference.** A city writ cites a book that never existed; build an Information Bridge to the nearest true source before the court rules from nothing.
2. **Errata Night.** Archivists purge lies; protect a friend's page from redaction—or convince the index it always belonged.
3. **The Folded Hall.** Two stacks overlap; map the "between" before a Leak of Names turns to amnesia.

Using Archive Keepers at the Table

Spend **errata slips** to downgrade *Sting/Inspection* into *Public Correction* [4]; deploy **Memory Palace** to capture a scene and later "quote" it for **Clue +1** or a decisive contradiction. **Threshold Architecture** grants the whole party a subtle shortcut *once/session*. Track **Overload** as Fatigue when too many inputs land at once; let **Index Sense** steer you to the next honest place a fact might live.

3.9 Cross-Module Integration (all three)

- **Violets & Stone:** Mazereth stabilize vaults; Umbral run parasol markets and mirror-oaths; Archive Keepers arbitrate contracts with Red Thread Courts.
- **Shadows & Steel:** Shadow-Step smuggling; seam-chalk routes under districts; errata slips to soften crackdowns.
- **Caravans/Wilderness:** Mazereth cut safe passes; Umbral guide night legs; Archive Keepers preserve manifests and ward-maps.
- **Political Intrigue:** Copper-witness oaths, mirror-witness oaths, and dual-ledger writs recognized as auxiliary evidence.
- **Psionics:** Information Bridges as noetic pathways; Deep Sense as tremor-sense; Umbral light-bending counters ward-storm glare.

Among the Aelinnel, sub-cultures are not splinters but lenses. The hill, the edge, the index—each teaches a way to keep to courtesy when the world tilts.

Omens & Oddities (roll or pick)

- **Spade:** Tide-rift steps with votive nails keeping count—safe when the nails agree.
- **Heart:** A hedge-witch prices cures in unleses; pay with a clause you can keep.
- **Club:** Hawthorn arch closes behind you; your footfalls no longer match your steps.
- **Diamond:** Hazel token allows one cut-free hedge crossing; the scratch you didn't get remembers you kindly.

Winged Kin (Faekin)

Some Aelinnel are born to the boughs, pinions veined like leaves. They keep the hawthorn courtesies as breath: no naked iron beyond an arch, always return what points the way, speak debts in daylight so leaves can hear. They are the surest messengers between keep and court—and the quickest to warn when counting turns wrong.

Play Hooks

1. **The Gate Wants Change:** The Green Gate opens at the wrong hour; pay a memory that fits the posted proof or roads rewire across your path.
2. **Kiln in Thirds:** A charcoal clan's draught hums off-pattern; smoke omens say a geas is miscounted. Set it straight before the court tithe arrives in flowers and warrants.
3. **Two Ledgers, One Lie:** A broker sells meanings at a green market; catch them in a one-ledger statement or produce a chilled oath-bead to void their trick.
4. **Antler-Posts Out of Order:** Posts have rearranged a stag road; foresters whisper that someone mocked the count. Restore the sequence before the Wild Hunt claims the short path.

Using Aelinnel at the Table (quick rules)

- **Count:** Once/scene, careful counting shifts Position +1 for patterned actions.
- **Copper:** In fae-facing scenes, copper/brass tools negate the first offense; iron escalates.
- **Said/Meant:** Declare both to cancel the first social SB; refuse, and the next bargain wants collateral (memory/name).
- **Hazel Favors:** Earn by respectful upkeep of way-things; spend to downgrade a glamour/geas once per leg.
- **Region SB (examples):** Hawthorn arch closes; petals cut like blades; moonlight reveals a hidden path.

In Aelinnel, numbers have manners. Keep the count, favor copper, return what points the way—and the hills will do the same for you.

3.10 Threshold Culture Stats Summary

Culture	Key Traits, Gifts, Complications
Aelaerem	Traits: Small; +1 Position in tight spaces; +1 die to Hide/Notice minute details Gifts (choose 2): Threshold Walking, Object Bond, Minute Craft, Liminal Sight Complications: Overlooked by surface powers; fragile in mass conflict Bond: Liminbound Cultural Tags: Hearth-Law, Lantern-Ward, Guest-Right, Festival Calendar
Mazereth	Traits: Medium-Small; +1 die underground; Pressure Adaptation Gifts: Deep Earthen Sense, Tunnel Craft, Pressure Resistance, Pattern Reading Complications: Surface sickness; light sensitivity (SB: Lantern Sway)
Umbral Kin	Traits: Variable scale (partial phase); Shadow Blend, Reflection Reading Gifts: Shadow Step, Memory Echo, Light Bending, Partial Phase Complications: Instability in bright light; attention from ward-lamps
Archive Keepers	Traits: MicroSmall scale shift; Information Sense, Scale Shift Gifts: Knowledge Tap, Memory Palace, Information Bridge, Threshold Architecture Complications: Overload sensitivity; bodily fragility

3.11 Nook/Clan Sheet (Template)

[NOOK / CLAN NAME] Culture: Aelaerem / Mazereth / Umbral Kin / Archive Keepers Venue: Pantry • Cellar • Beams • Hedge • Roof • Shrine Tags (2–3): Gnaw-Holes • Ferrier Line • Secret Hooks • Crumb-Bank • Ward Pins • Lantern Lookouts • Root-Road Strings (2–3): door-charm bead • pantry tithe token • ferrier token • under-map • cat’s truce knot • witness broom badge Tracks: - Repute [6] (standing among threshold folk) - Notice [6] (ambient risk from Bigfolk/Predators) - Threshold Sense [6] (opt., cultural) - Visibility [6] (opt., public awareness) Bank (tiny economy); Allies/Rivals; Nooks/Routes Gifts (2): _____ Realm Bond (1): _____ Hidden Knowledge (1): _____ Surface Connection (1): _____ Nook Benefits (choose 1): Ferrier Line • Ward Pins • Lantern Lookouts

3.12 Threshold Tracks (optional layer)

Threshold Sense6 — connection to liminal spaces

0–2: disconnected (Gifts weaken; Position –1 on realm moves)

3–4: steady access

5–6: deep current (Gifts enhanced) but visible to entities (Threshold Tension +1 when you flex)

Visibility6 — how noticeable you are to surface powers

0–2: overlooked (Stealth +1 die in crowds)

3–4: normal

5–6: high profile (authorities begin Lantern Watch [4])

Realm Stability6 — health of your home realm

0–2: unstable (realm sickness risk)

3–4: stable

5–6: overconnected (pulled toward realm; DV +1 to resist)

Threshold Tension4 — pressure with guardians/veils. At full: crisis, closing, or entity attention

Mapping (low-overhead): If you prefer fewer dials, treat Visibility Notice, and let Realm Stability/Threshold Tension be represented by relevant Front timers

3.13 Gifts & Abilities

Movement & Scale Size Shift, Threshold Walking, Realm Step, Scale Mastery

Perception & Knowledge Liminal Sight, Micro-Sense, Pattern Reading, Memory Echo

Craft & Creation Minute Work, Object Bond, Realm Infusion, Threshold Architecture

Gifts are narrative permissions; most grant Position, DV, or Effect shifts once per scene/leg as listed

3.14 Realm Bonds & Complications

Bonds (pick 1):

Earthbound, Shadowtouched, Liminbound, Knowledgebound

Common Complications:

Scale Shock, Realm Sickness, Oversight, Threshold Attention, Cycle Dependency

3.15 Threshold Maps & Venues

Nodes (pick 4–6):

Pantry Court • Beams & Rafters • Gutter Run • Hedge Road • Cellar City • Shrine in the Mould • Timer -Room • Mill-Loft • Postern Stairs • Under-Dock Piles

Local Timers:

Bigfolk Stir [6], Lantern Watch [4], Cat's Prowl [4]

3.16 Ladders & Procedures

Underway Travel Ladders

Foot/Climb: DV 2 hooks • 3 beams • 4 pipes • 5 storm vent

Leaf-Ferry: DV 2 basin • 3 drain • 4 gutter run • 5 downspout

Venue Effects

Beams & Rafters: Infiltrate/Traverse Position +1 (Small); Big suffer Position -1

Pantry Court: Market Position +1 with tithe token; on 1, Notice +1

3.17 Hidden Knowledge & Surface Connections**Hidden Knowledge Types:**

- Secret route map
- Household weakness
- Predator schedule
- Realm boundary location
- Ancient compact terms
- Craft technique
- Patron whisper

Surface Connections:

- Human patron
- Guild contact
- Merchant relationship
- Authority blind spot
- Family tie
- Debt owed/owed to you

3.18 Integration with Existing Modules**Violets & Stone:**

Hidden communities in district underways, secret services, threshold points in ancient buildings

Wilderness:

Natural threshold spaces, small folk as guides, realm connections to natural features

Caravans:

Specialized small-scale trade goods, hidden route knowledge, realm-based preservation

Political Intrigue:

Secret advisors, hidden faction members, threshold-based communication networks

3.19 Adventure Frameworks

Score Types:

- Borrowing Heist
- Rescue & Return
- Underway Escort
- Oath Moot
- Threshold Intrusion
- Knowledge Quest

New Score Types:

- **Realm Crisis:** Home realm becoming unstable
-
- **Boundary War:** Conflict between threshold entities
- **Predator Hunt:** Dangerous entity threatening communities
- **Cycle Disruption:** Natural rhythms disturbed

Crumb & Candle SB:

Environmental complications, bigfolk attention, predator signs, realm instability

3.20 Generators & Tables

Threshold Venues (d12):

1. Pantry Court
2. Beams & Rafters
3. Gutter Run
4. Hedge Road
5. Cellar City
6. Shrine in Mould
7. Timer -Room
8. Mill-Loft
9. Postern Stairs
10. Under-Dock Piles
11. Root-Warren
12. Shadow Gap

Small Folk Complications (d10):

1. Broom sweep
2. Lantern sway
3. Cat prowl
4. Ferrier dispute
5. Ward draft
6. Bigfolk stir
7. Cycle shift
8. Predator scent
9. Realm tremor
10. Compact breach

3.21 GM Toolkit**3.22 Cultural Deep-Dives**

Aelaerem Society: The Aelaerem organize into hearth-clans centered around craft specialties—coopers, weavers, brewers, and woodcarvers who maintain both trade secrets and seasonal rituals. Each clan keeps a memory-weaver who tracks debts, favors, and omens across generations through story-braids and token-craft. Information flows through guest-right networks and festival moots, where the Apple-Matron mediates disputes through feast-law and proverb-wrights. Threshold guardians like the Pale Shepherd are honored with offerings and careful observance; slight them and household luck turns sour. Clan tokens—bread-seals, lantern-writs, and red-thread knots—serve as both currency and covenant, creating an economy where reputation weighs more than coin. p0.27 p0.68 **Aelaerem — People of the Hearth Levers:** Bread & Salt = Position +1 once/scene; Broom Witness = Oath [4–6]; Iron-Lace & Red Thread = +1 Effect vs. compulsion. **Strings:** guest-loaf, broom badge, hedge measure. **Tensions:** Barrow Stirring [6], Gloam Choir [6].

Mazereth Engineering: Mazereth architecture operates on pressure harmonics, where pillars, arches, and support beams are tuned to resonate at frequencies that strengthen stone rather than strain it. Master builders read stress-lines in rock like maps, placing copper nodes at compression points and iron dampeners at tension zones. Their deep history is preserved in geological strata—glyphs carved into cave walls that tell stories through the ages as erosion reveals new layers. Tunnel network politics revolve around bearing-rights and seam-access; clans feud over prime ventilation shafts and mineral veins, settling disputes through measured duels where contestants must navigate obstacle courses while maintaining perfect step-counts and load-balances. **Mazereth — Deep Tunnelers Levers:** Deep Earthen Sense = Navigate DV −1 underground; Copper Nails avoid first "hill offense"; Count the Load = Position +1 on Traverse/Endure. **Strings:** seam-chalk, bearing cord, pressure bead. **Tensions:** Stone Attention [6], Bad Air [4].

Umbral Kin Memory: Umbral Kin share memories through dream-reflection, where important experiences are "polished" until they gleam bright enough to be caught in glass surfaces and still water. Reflection communication allows instant long-distance contact—messages passed from mirror to mirror across a city's windows can traverse miles in moments. Shadow realm territorial disputes arise when one group's reflections begin overlapping another's; boundaries are negotiated through careful light-management and shadow-casting protocols. Memory Echo allows Umbral to read emotional residue from surfaces, making them excellent investigators but also vulnerable to psychic pollution from traumatic events embedded in walls and floors. **Umbral Kin — Shadow-Adjacent Levers:** Covered Light avoids first ward-lamp penalty; Mirror Oath = Witness; Shadow Step (short hop) & Light Bending = Position +1 to vanish.

Strings: parasol writ, mirror shard, lamp hood. **Tensions:** Ward-Lamp Attention [6], Blue Hour Drift [4].

*Archive Keeper Knowledge: Archive Keepers store information in pattern-webs—three-dimensional mental constructs that connect related facts across multiple dimensions of meaning. Scale-shifting libraries exist in probability space, where books grow larger or smaller depending on the reader's need for detail; a general overview might require accessing a text the size of a grain of sand, while deep research could mean entering a tome the size of a cathedral. Knowledge debt systems track intellectual borrowing—when an Archive Keeper accesses another's memory palace or information bridge, they owe a tithe of new knowledge or a favor in return. The most dangerous debts are memetic—ideas that carry obligations or change the borrower's thinking patterns. **Archive Keepers — Knowledge-Bound Levers:** Cite or be Cited = DV -1 (Plan/Research); Errata Slip downgrades Sting→Public Correction [4]; Threshold Architecture = Traverse DV -1 (once/session). **Strings:** errata slip, binder's thread, catalog tag. **Tensions:** Index Entropy [6], Redaction [6].

Portrayal Notes:

- **Emphasize capability over diminutive stereotypes:** These cultures are not weak or helpless despite their size—they are experts in their environments with sophisticated knowledge systems. Show them as competent specialists who solve problems through precision, timing, and deep understanding of their realms rather than brute force.
- **Show complex societies with internal diversity:** Each culture has factions, dissenters, reformers, and outliers. The Aelaerem have those who reject hospitality laws, Mazereth include those who favor iron over copper, Umbral Kin struggle with those who crave bright light, and Archive Keepers debate the ethics of memory manipulation. Not every member adheres strictly to cultural norms.
- **Use hospitality and reciprocity as mechanical hooks:** Treat guest-right, copper courtesy, mirror-oaths, and citation protocols as more than flavor—they're tactical resources. Characters can spend cultural tokens for mechanical benefits, but violating these codes creates escalating complications that drive scenes forward.
- **Balance hidden advantages with genuine vulnerabilities:** While these cultures have unique gifts and knowledge, they also face real limitations. Aelaerem are fragile in mass conflict, Mazereth suffer surface sickness, Umbral Kin are unstable in bright light, and Archive Keepers risk overload. Their strengths come with meaningful costs that create interesting choices.

Scene Framing:

- **Start in threshold spaces or realm boundaries:** Begin scenes at doorways, hedges, cave entrances, shadow edges, or between bookshelves. These liminal zones are where threshold cultures are strongest and where their unique abilities shine. Let the environment provide tactical advantages and narrative hooks.
- **Use scale for tactical variety:** Design encounters that highlight size differences—small PCs can use tight spaces, hide in unexpected places, or exploit environmental hazards that don't affect larger characters. Big PCs can provide brute force solutions but may struggle with finesse requirements or environmental navigation.
- **Frame conflicts around access and visibility:** Tension often comes from who can go where and who knows what. Information control, territorial disputes, and questions of who gets to cross thresholds create natural dramatic friction without resorting to simple combat encounters.
- **Let cultural differences drive narrative tension:** Conflicts arise from different value systems—Aelaerem hospitality vs. Mazereth precision, Umbral Kin secrecy vs. Archive Keeper transparency, surface urgency vs. threshold patience. These philosophical differences create compelling roleplay opportunities.

Integration Hooks:

- **Hidden communities beneath existing venues:** Every major location in your campaign world has threshold spaces—the walls of a palace house Aelaerem guest-halls, the foundation stones contain Mazereth tunnels, the chandeliers cast Umbral reflection-lanes, and the library stacks hide Archive Keeper sanctums. These communities can provide aid, information, or complications.
- **Small folk as information brokers:** These cultures excel at gathering and trading information through their networks. Aelaerem hearth-clans know everyone's business, Mazereth tunnels connect distant locations, Umbral Kin read emotional residue, and Archive Keepers maintain vast information webs. They make excellent contacts for investigation scenarios.
- **Realm connections to major plot points:** Threshold spaces often intersect with significant locations—ancient vaults exist partially in threshold realms, important artifacts are hidden in scale-shifting spaces, political negotiations happen in neutral threshold zones, and supernatural threats emerge from realm boundaries. These cultures provide access to plot-critical locations.
- **Scale-based tactical opportunities:** Create scenarios where size differences matter tactically—small PCs can sabotage large mechanisms, infiltrate secure areas, or deliver messages through impossible routes, while big PCs can provide protection, move heavy objects, or serve as mobile platforms for smaller allies.

3.23 Example of Play

Setup: An Aelaerem craftsperson named Thistle works with the surface merchant guild to investigate reports of a haunted vault beneath the old marketplace. Thistle brings Object Bond (lockpick expertise), Threshold Walking (navigation of liminal spaces), and a Liminbound bond (connection to threshold spaces). The guild provides resources and legal authority, but they're dependent on Thistle's unique abilities to access the vault's hidden sections.

Scene: The vault exists partially in threshold space, with some chambers accessible normally and others requiring passage through liminal boundaries. Thistle uses Threshold Walking to navigate sections that shift between dimensions, Object Bond to pick precision locks that respond to careful touch rather than force, and her Liminbound bond to sense stable passages versus areas that might collapse or shift unexpectedly. The guild representatives follow with lanterns and tools, but they're operating outside their expertise.

Complications: As Thistle delves deeper, her actions increase Threshold Tension, attracting the attention of a territorial threshold guardian who begins manifesting as locked doors that reappear after being opened and shadows that move against the light. Meanwhile, the guild masters above notice unusual activity and begin asking questions, raising Visibility and creating pressure to complete the job quickly. The vault's unstable nature threatens Realm Stability—walls occasionally shift, passages close temporarily, and the boundary between threshold and normal space becomes less distinct.

Resolution: Success reveals that the "haunting" was actually a Mazereth clan using the vault's threshold sections as a shortcut between their deep tunnels and surface access points. They were inadvertently disrupting the space through their passage. Thistle brokers a compromise—establishing proper guest-right protocols and payment in copper nails that strengthen the vault's structure. The solution opens new connections between surface and threshold communities but also increases Notice and Visibility, making Thistle a known quantity to both guild authorities and other threshold cultures who may seek her services in the future.

Chapter 4

Beastfolk, Dragonfolk, and Others

4.1 Overview

In *Fate's Edge*, Beastfolk, Dragonfolk, and Others are not common “races” but rare, mythic outliers. They dwell primarily in the Valewood and the deep Wilds, rarely appearing in human lands except as rumors, omens, or the subject of contradictory stories.

These origins are intended to:

- Emphasize **rarity and narrative weight**.
- Tie directly into core systems: Position & Effect, Story Beats (SB), Boons, Fatigue, Obligation, and Patrons.
- Root nonhuman characters in specific places and stories rather than generic ancestry.

4.1.1 Using Nonhuman Origins

GM Guidance. Nonhuman PCs should remain uncommon. As a default:

- Limit to **0–1 nonhuman PC** per party unless the campaign is primarily set in the Valewood or Wilds.
- In human lands, nonhumans always shift Position & Effect:
 - Social actions often start from worse Position (risky or desperate), but can achieve higher Effect when leaning into fear, myth, or awe.
- Nonhuman PCs should come with explicit ties: a Patron, a forest court, a dragon enclave, an old debt, or a prophecy.

The “Other in Human Lands” Timer . When a Beastfolk, Dragonfolk, or Other PC moves openly in human lands, the GM creates an “Otherness” timer for that community (4–6 segments, as appropriate).

- Each time the PC acts in a conspicuous way, mark 1 segment.
- When the timer fills, introduce a consequence: hunters, scholars, inquisitors, curious nobles, street rumors, or religious panic.

This timer replaces ambient prejudice with focused, story-relevant pressure.

4.2 Beastfolk

Where the road ends, the people of fur and claw remember no empire but the forest. Beastfolk are Lethai rewritten by the Wild through old pacts, curses, or bloodlines bound to animal spirits. They exist as reminders that civilization is not the only intelligence on the map.

4.2.1 Culture and Place

Beastfolk clans are loosely aligned with:

- **Valewood Circles:** semi-nomadic bands tied to groves, standing stones, or ancient trails.
- **Wild Moots:** rare gatherings where multiple clans, and sometimes Others, negotiate seasonal rites, borders, and common threats.

The fallen Utar Empire is remembered as an infection that burned out. Human kingdoms are regarded as lingering fever, not the natural order.

Common archetypes include:

- **Wolf-blooded:** pack-minded scouts and guardians.
- **Stag-marked:** antlered wanderers, tied to sacrifice and omen.
- **Raven-tongued:** tricksters and memory-keepers.
- **Bear-hearted:** slow to anger, anchors of their communities, unstoppable when roused.

4.2.2 Core Feature: Beast Instinct

When you create a Beastfolk character, choose an **Instinct** that defines how the Wild speaks through you:

- **Hunt** (stalk, pursue, reveal weakness)
- **Guard** (protect, endure, stand firm)
- **Wander** (roam, explore, cross boundaries)
- **Trick** (misdirect, unsettle, reframe)

Instinct Move. Once per scene, when you clearly act in line with your Instinct in a risky moment:

- Gain **+1 die** to the roll.
- On a hit, the GM gains **+1 SB** to spend later on complications tied to the Wild or your nature.

If you deliberately betray your Instinct to secure safety or comfort, the GM may:

- Mark **+1 Fatigue**, or
- Mark **+1 segment** on your personal *Alienation from the Wild* timer (4 segments).

When the timer fills, you owe the Wild—or a Patron of the Wild—a serious price to reconcile who you have become.

4.2.3 Beastfolk Talents

Keen Scent of the Valewood (6 XP)

You can “read” a scene with your senses.

- Once per scene in the Wilds, when you **Study** or **Take Stock**, you may ask *one additional question* on a hit.
- The GM marks **+1 SB** tied to an unseen predator, rival clan, or old obligation.

Run With the Pack (8 XP)

You are never truly alone.

- When you fight or act alongside an ally who trusts you, you both gain **+1 Effect** when you coordinate using pack tactics (flanking, driving prey, trading blows).
- On a miss, the GM may mark **+1 Harm** or **+1 Fatigue** on an ally instead of you; your instinctive coordination pulls them into danger.

4.3 Dragonfolk

Where a dragon died screaming, someone always wakes up different. Dragonfolk are not full dragons, but living fault-lines where draconic power has leaked into blood, bone, and story.

Some claim descent from ancient wyrms of the mountains; others were changed by proximity to hoards, old lairs, or dragon-Patrons. In human lands, most people have never seen a Dragonfolk and would not believe in them outside of folktales.

Common archetypes include:

- **Ashscale**: scarred by volcanic fire, eyes smoldering with embers.
- **Stormblood**: hair and scales crackling with static, voice like thunder.
- **Deepcoil**: serpentine, cold-eyed, hungry for secrets and leverage.
- **Shardsoul**: reflective, glassy scales, obsessed with memory and perfection.

4.3.1 Core Feature: Draconic Echo

Choose one **Echo**, a thematic way that dragon-nature manifests in you:

- **Fire** (fury, destruction, passion)
- **Storm** (change, disruption, omen)
- **Hoard** (possession, memory, obsession)
- **Dominion** (authority, command, pride)

Echo Move. Once per scene, when you invoke your Echo:

- Describe how it shapes your presence (heat in the air, rumbling voice, unblinking gaze, the scent of rain, etc.).
- Gain **+1 die** to actions that rely on force of personality (such as **Command**, **Sway**, or similar moves).

On a hit, the GM gains **+1 SB**, earmarked for *dragon-shaped consequences*: old debts, dragon cults, relic awakenings, rival Dragonfolk, or attention from a dragon-Patron.

If you refuse to draw on your Echo in a moment where it would clearly help, mark **+1 Fatigue**; you are fighting your own nature.

4.3.2 Dragonblooded Resilience

Dragonfolk shrug off some threats but attract others.

- You gain **+1 armor** against Fire, Lightning, or Fear effects when it is fictionally appropriate.
- Artifacts, wards, and Rites that bind or repel “dragons and their kin” also affect you, even if they were not meant for your specific bloodline.

4.3.3 Dragonfolk Talents

Hoard-Sense (6 XP)

You can feel where stories and value pool.

- When you **Survey** a location for treasure, secrets, or leverage, on a hit you may also ask: “What here would I be most tempted to claim and keep?”
- If you pursue that answer, gain **+1 die** on the relevant action.
- If you walk away from it, the GM may mark **+1 SB** for future temptation.

Draconic Breath (12 XP, Tier II+)

You have learned to vent a fraction of the dragon-fire (or storm, frost, venom) in your blood.

- Once per session, you may unleash a **Breath Attack** as a risky or desperate action.
- Gain **+2 Effect** against a group or large target when you do so.
- After using it, mark **+2 Fatigue**. If this would cause overflow, the GM instead marks **+1 SB** and you gain a new visible draconic mutation (eyes, scales, voice, or other change).

4.4 Others

The world remembers its own dreams, and sometimes they wake up in the shape of people. The **Others** are those not wholly of the mortal world: fae-touched, gloam-born, children of forgotten Rites, or walkers between dreams and waking.

They stand at boundaries: between Valewood myth and human history, between one Patron’s claim and another’s silence.

Common archetypes include:

- **Gloam-touched**: eyes like dusk, never fully in one light or shadow.
- **Hollow-bound**: something else peers out through their eyes, patient and curious.
- **Green-vowed**: sworn to a forest, river, stone circle, or ancient tree.
- **Masks of Dawn**: can pass as human until the wrong light hits them.

4.4.1 Core Feature: Liminal Nature

Choose one **Liminal Axis** that defines your between-ness:

- **Dream / Waking**
- **Forest / City**
- **Life / Death**
- **Memory / Forgetting**

Liminal Move. When you act to *bridge* or *exploit* your Axis:

- Gain **+1 die** to the roll.
- On a hit, the GM may mark **+1 SB** to introduce consequences that blur reality: time slippage, lost memories, omens, strange visitors, and similar effects.

4.4.2 Bound Obligation

Others rarely exist without a binding.

Choose one:

- **Bound to a Place** (a sacred grove, crossroads, riverbend).
- **Bound to a Story** (prophecy, curse, legend, song).
- **Bound to a Being** (Patron, ancient spirit, sleeping dragon, forest court).

Write one sentence:

“I am bound to _____ and must _____.”

Any time you defy this Bond in a major way:

- The GM may mark **+2 SB**, or
- Immediately introduce a supernatural consequence tied to your Bond.

Any time you honor it at serious personal cost:

- Clear **2 Fatigue**, or
- Mark **+1 Boon** for later use.

4.4.3 Talents for Others

Step Sideways (8 XP)

You move through liminal spaces as if they were doors.

- Once per scene, when you move through a threshold (doorway, tree-line, fog bank, mirror, or similar boundary), you may *reposition* yourself or an ally fictionally: appear behind foes, bypass mundane guards, or “skip” a short distance.
- Roll the appropriate move. On a hit, you arrive where and how you intended.
- On a miss, you arrive altered, late, or not alone. The GM marks **+1 SB** tied to what followed you.

Unsettling Truth (6 XP)

You can speak in the language of omens.

- When you **Sway**, **Provoke**, or **Command** by revealing a hidden truth, omen, or uncanny insight about someone, gain **+1 Effect** on a hit.
- The target is left shaken or marked by dread or hope (GM’s choice).
- On a miss, they reject you and label you a danger or blasphemy; mark **+1 Fatigue**.

4.5 Adventure Hooks

Use these peoples to complicate the Valewood and Wilds rather than simply populate them.

4.5.1 The Beastfolk Hunt

A Beastfolk circle believes a human village has broken an ancient trail-compact. They are hunting a “trespasser” who is actually a human PC or ally. Can the party negotiate new terms before blood is spilled?

4.5.2 Dragon’s Debt

A Dragonfolk PC’s Echo stirs an ancient dragon from dormancy. The dragon demands repayment for a boon given to their bloodline long ago—or offers patronage that could reshape the region.

4.5.3 The Vanishing Grove

An Other bound to a sacred grove feels it thinning. Human loggers, Utar relic-hunters, or a rising Patron’s followers are siphoning its power. Saving it may mean undermining a human ally or opposing a Patron the party relies on.

4.5.4 The “Monster” in the City

Rumors spread of a “beast-headed killer” in a human city. The culprit is a terrified Beastfolk youth, trapped far from the Valewood and hunted by scholars and zealots. Do the PCs smuggle them home, conceal them, or weaponize the panic?